

NASA's Artemis III: A Giant Space Dance Before We Go Back to the Moon!

From: ScienceDaily Most Popular Mined: 2026-06-11 3 min read

Have you ever tried to high-five a friend while both of you are running? Now imagine doing that in space, at 17,000 miles per hour, with two giant spaceships! That's exactly what NASA's Artemis III mission will do in 2027.

NASA just announced the four astronauts who will fly this super-exciting mission: Randy Bresnik, Luca Parmitano, Frank Rubio, and Andre Douglas. They'll ride the Orion spacecraft into Earth **orbit**, where they'll meet up with test versions of lunar **landers** built by Blue Origin and SpaceX. It's like a space dance, but way more complicated!

"This mission will require the most awe-inspiring **coordination** of heavy-lift rocket launches in history," said NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman. The plan is wild: first, Blue Origin's **lander** will launch and wait in **orbit**. Then Orion will blast off, dock with it, and the crew will float inside to test everything. After two days, they'll separate and wait for SpaceX's Starship to arrive for another day of **docking** tests.

Why all this practice? Because Artemis IV, set for 2028, will actually land astronauts on the Moon's South Pole. Artemis III is the crucial **dress rehearsal**. Luca Parmitano's role is also **historic** he's the first European Space Agency astronaut on an Artemis mission. So, get ready for a new Golden Age of exploration, just like the Apollo days, but with even cooler tech!

Word Treasure

orbit -- The curved path a spaceship or moon follows around a planet or star.

lander -- A spacecraft designed to touch down softly on a surface like the Moon.

docking -- The tricky job of connecting two spacecraft together in space.

coordination -- Organising many moving parts so they all work together smoothly.

historic -- Something so important it will be remembered in history books.

dress rehearsal -- A final full practice before the real big event, like a play before opening night.

Background you need

The Artemis program is NASA's plan to send humans back to the Moon for the first time since the Apollo missions (which landed astronauts on the Moon from 1969 to 1972).

Blue Origin (a space company founded by Jeff Bezos) and SpaceX (a space company founded by Elon Musk) are building the new lunar landers that will carry astronauts to the Moon's surface.

The Moon's South Pole has permanently shadowed craters with water ice, which could be used to support future human bases.

Break it down

WHO: Four astronauts -- Randy Bresnik, Luca Parmitano, Frank Rubio, and Andre Douglas.

WHAT: They will fly to Earth orbit and test docking with two different lunar landers from Blue Origin and SpaceX.

WHERE: In orbit around Earth, before any trip to the Moon.

WHY: Artemis III is a dress rehearsal for Artemis IV, which will land astronauts on the Moon's South Pole in 2028.

Why it matters

This mission is one step closer to people living and working on the Moon, and you might grow up to work in space science or even travel there yourself.

Test what you remember

1. What is the name of the NASA mission that will practice docking in space before landing on the Moon again?
 - (A) Apollo III
 - (B) Artemis III
 - (C) Starship I
 - (D) Orion I
2. What will the astronauts test in Earth orbit?
 - (A) New space suits on a spacewalk
 - (B) Lunar landers built by Blue Origin and SpaceX
 - (C) A new space telescope
 - (D) Mars rover wheels
3. Who is the first European Space Agency astronaut on an Artemis mission?
 - (A) Randy Bresnik
 - (B) Frank Rubio
 - (C) Luca Parmitano
 - (D) Andre Douglas
4. How fast will the spacecraft be moving when they try to dock?
 - (A) 1,000 miles per hour
 - (B) 17,000 miles per hour
 - (C) 100,000 miles per hour
 - (D) 500 miles per hour
5. Which mission will actually land astronauts on the Moon's South Pole?
 - (A) Artemis I
 - (B) Artemis II
 - (C) Artemis III
 - (D) Artemis IV
6. What did NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman say the mission would require?
 - (A) The fastest rocket ever
 - (B) The most awe-inspiring coordination of heavy-lift rocket launches in history
 - (C) A new type of fuel
 - (D) Astronauts to stay awake for a week

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: C 4: B 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

- 1. Excited Space Fan:** This is the most thrilling Moon program since Apollo, with cool new technology and private companies joining the adventure.
- 2. Cautionary Viewpoint:** Docking experiments with heavy, fast-moving spacecraft are risky and expensive; a small mistake could cost billions and delay everything.
- 3. International Cooperation:** Having an ESA astronaut aboard shows that going to the Moon is now a team effort across many countries, sharing the cost and the glory.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):